

Tamil Nadu, was once India’s largest copper smelting facility. It accounted for roughly 40% of the country’s domestic refining capacity. However, it has been shut since 2018, following protests and a local environmental dispute that escalated into a permanent closure.

The shutdown of a single facility removing 40% of national refining capacity has coincided with the steepest ramp-up in copper demand in the country. This has resulted in imports filling a domestic processing gap. The Ministry of Mine’s Vision Document on Copper Sector, 2025 states that India has heavy reliance on imported copper concentrate, with about 66% sourced from just three countries.

“Enhancing exploration activities will be crucial in expanding geological resources, allowing India to tap into its domestic potential more effectively. Additionally, adopting emerging technologies can boost mine productivity in existing operations. Alongside this, acquiring or investing in foreign assets is essential to secure a long-term copper supply, helping India mitigate its heavy reliance on imports of primary raw material,” report says.

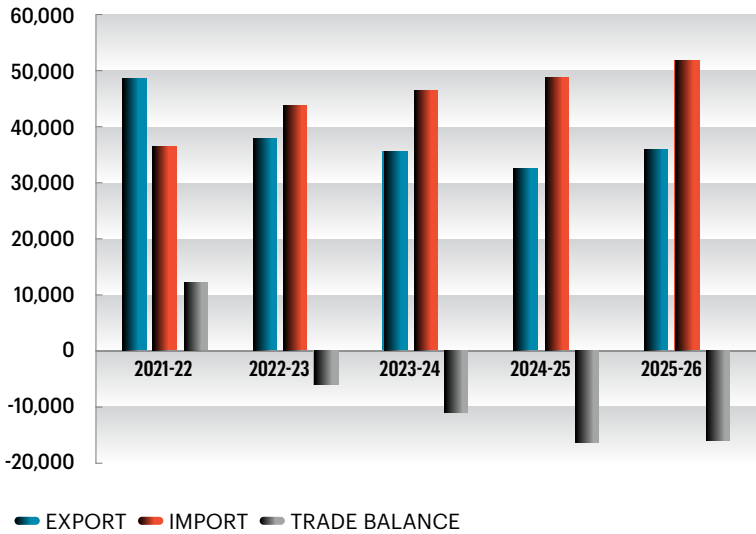
The report also highlighted that, “India lacks specific guidelines for copper scrap quality to improve dependency on scrap, unlike China’s stringent policies. Heavily dependent on imports of copper concentrate due to weak domestic resource base, recycling is going to play a major role in meeting the demand.”

IRON ORE

If copper’s story is about a sudden supply shock meeting surging demand, iron ore’s story is more structural because it cannot be

INDIA ONCE MINED WHAT IT NOW IMPORTS

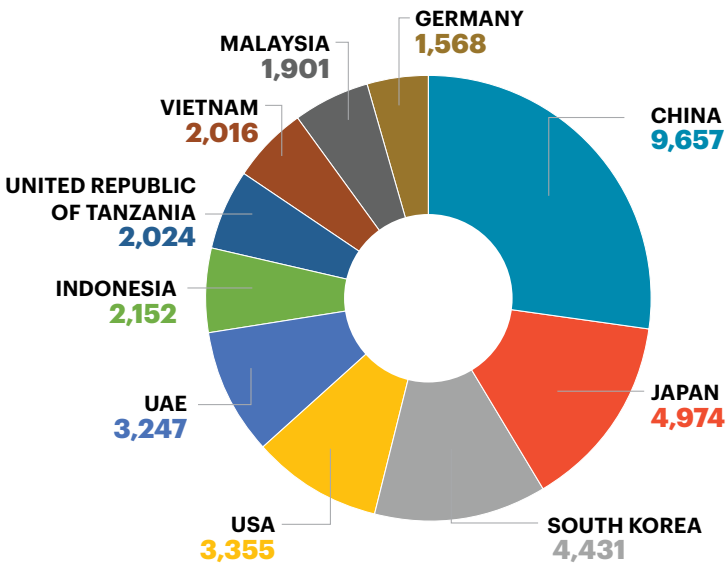
• India’s imports and exports of base metals over the years



NOTE FIGURES IN \$ MILLION
SOURCE MINISTRY OF COMMERCE & INDUSTRY

WHERE INDIA'S METAL REALLY COMES FROM?

• Six of India's top ten suppliers are in Asia



NOTE IMPORTS (\$ MN)
SOURCE MINISTRY OF COMMERCE & INDUSTRY